



SIPRA DAS

INTERVIEW | MADHAV KUMAR NEPAL

"Update the 1950 FRIENDSHIP TREATY"

On his visit to India, Prime Minister of Nepal Madhav Kumar Nepal sat down for an exclusive interview with Senior Editor SAURABH SHUKLA. Excerpts:

Q. What are the big deliverables from your first visit to India?

A. I want this visit to deepen our bilateral ties and take our relationship to new heights.

Q. A thorny issue is the renegotiation of the Friendship Treaty. What is your stand now?

A. Our view is that the 1950 treaty with India must be reviewed, updated and adjusted. We expect that understanding should be implemented.

Q. What about the extradition treaty? Why is it getting delayed?

A. During this visit, there was no time. We need an understanding with political parties in Nepal before we move forward.

Q. Will Maoists try to topple your Government?

A. Every Opposition has the right to dislodge the Government through legitimate means. Let them try.

Q. Will your Government last long?

A. Why not? There are coalition governments which have worked well even with 60 different constituents. If they can co-exist, we can do it as well.

Q. Will they take up arms again?

A. Yes, there is a suspicion that Maoists may resort to extreme measures. They will go back to their rebellious ways.

Q. But their leader Prachanda has been issuing threats.

A. I think the people of Nepal will not tolerate the extreme activities of the Maoists now. What they are doing is a pressure tactic.

Q. But what about the Maoists Young Communist League? They are still using violent means.

A. Yes, it is a big problem. They have not changed their ways, and we need to sort it out.

Q. India is worried that anti-India elements are using your territory.

A. Nepal's territory will not be allowed to be used against India or any other neighbouring country.

Q. There is some concern here that Chinese influence is growing in Nepal.

A. Nepal is aware of the concerns and we will respect the sensitivities of neighbours like India.

Q. Can you assure India that no third country will be allowed to harm the Indo-Nepal friendship?

A. We will not allow any third country to do that. Nepal is an independent and sovereign country. We will decide how to move ahead and manage its relationship with friends like India.

with the Maoists who need to stay afloat in the political mainstream. New Delhi needs to assist the new Government with law enforcement and security cooperation to work out a better border management policy.

The key is development and to demonstrate that these projects will benefit the people of Nepal by generating employment and bringing economic opportunities. India could replicate the Afghanistan reconstruction model in the country, with a number of small development projects

in areas such as education and health. Nepal has a potential of about 75,000 MW of power and stakes need to be created for it to shed its reservations on having hydropower projects assisted by India. Besides, India needs to tone up its public diplomacy in Nepal, because despite friends in the political establishment and close cultural and family links, a concerted anti-Indian sentiment is gaining ground that undermines every little step the country invests in its Nepal relationship. A major step forward would be to rejig the

1950 Friendship Treaty which guarantees a special relationship between India and Nepal by introducing provisions that will meet its concerns while underscoring the special relationship between the two countries.

If the failed experiment with Prachanda has taught any lesson, Indian diplomacy will have to be more innovative and will have to shed the sphere of influence mindset by being sensitive to local concerns, even as India continues to nurture its relationship with the Himalayan nation. ■